

P0553R1: Bit operations

Introduction

This paper proposes to add simple free functions for basic bit operations on all unsigned integer types.

A previous proposal was in "N3864: A constexpr bitwise operations library for C++" by Matthew Fioravante.

The papers P0237Rx propose to introduce `bit_value`, `bit_reference`, and `bit_iterator`, higher-level concepts for manipulating individual bits and sequences of bits. In order to implement efficient standard algorithms on `bit_iterator`, it is expected that implementations use the facilities presented in this paper. By directly exposing the low-level facilities to programmers, they can use them for their own purposes, independent of higher-level abstractions in the standard library.

It is expected that the functions provided with this proposal will be, at some later time, overloaded for `std::datapar`, the nascent SIMD data type (see P0214R2: "Data-Parallel Vector Types & Operations" by Matthias Kretz).

Changes

P0553R0 was favorably reviewed by SG6 (including the function names) and forwarded to LEWG. There are only editorial changes in the P0553R1 revision of the paper.

Design considerations

These operations can be made available either in the `<bit>` header proposed by P0237R4, or in a separate header. Given the different levels of abstraction, a separate header is proposed here.

The bit rotation operations are not limited to rotation counts less than the bit-width of the integer; it seems most (all?) CPU instruction sets support longer rotations by simply discarding upper bits. Different from bit shifts, this behavior is reasonable because rotating a 32-bit quantity by 33 bits is indistinguishable from rotating it by 1 bit.

The counting operations return "int" quantities, consistent with the rule "use an int unless you need something else". This choice does not reflect, in the type, the fact that counts are always non-negative.

This proposal uses readable English names for the operations, except that "left" (towards/affecting the most significant bits) and "right" (towards/affecting the least significant bits) is abbreviate "l" and "r", respectively. The use of "left" and "right" in the operation names is consistent with the "left" and "right" built-in shift operators.

An earlier draft of this paper had names such as "countl1", but lower-case "ell" and the digit "one" are nearly indistinguishable in some fonts, so now a name like "countl_one" is proposed. This is slightly baroque, so alternatively "countl(T, bool)" could be used, with the understanding that the second parameter is often a compile-time constant, allowing for optimization opportunities.

Per prevailing LWG convention, only those functions are marked `noexcept` that have a wide construct, i.e. no restrictions on the values of the function arguments.

All functions are marked `constexpr`, assuming that either compiler intrinsics that work in constant evaluation are available to the implementation, or the optimizer is good enough to use the appropriate hardware instructions for operations described with potentially verbose expressions with built-in operators.

A tangentially related `std::bit_cast` is proposed in P0476R1: "Bit-casting object representations" by JF Bastien.

Hardware

This is an incomplete table showing the extent of hardware support for the proposed operations.

operation	Intel/AMD	ARM	PowerPC
rotr	ROL	-	rldicl

rotr	ROR	ROR, EXTR	-
popcount	POPCNT	-	popcntb
countl_zero	BSR, LZCNT	CLZ	cntlzd
countl_one	-	CLS	-
countr_zero	BSF, TZCNT	-	-
countr_one	-	-	-

Wording

Add the header <bit_ops> to the table in 17.5.1.2 [headers].

Append a new subsection to clause 20 [utilities] with the following content:

23.20 Bit operations [bitops]

23.20.1 Header <bit_ops> synopsis [bit_ops.syn]

```
namespace std {
inline namespace bit_ops {
// 23.20.2, rotating
template<class T>
constexpr T rotl(T x, unsigned int s) noexcept;
template<class T>
constexpr T rotr(T x, unsigned int s) noexcept;

// 23.20.3, counting
template<class T>
constexpr int countl_zero(T x) noexcept;
template<class T>
constexpr int countl_one(T x) noexcept;
template<class T>
constexpr int countr_zero(T x) noexcept;
template<class T>
constexpr int countr_one(T x) noexcept;
template<class T>
constexpr int popcount(T x) noexcept;
}
}
```

In the following descriptions, let N denote `std::numeric_limits<T>::digits`.

23.20.2 Rotating [bitops.rot]

```
template<class T>
constexpr T rotl(T x, unsigned int s) noexcept;
```

Returns: `s % N == 0 ? x : (x << (s % N)) | (x >> (N - (s % N)))`;

Remarks: Participates in overload resolution only if T is an unsigned integer type (3.9.1 [basic.fundamental]).

```
template<class T>
constexpr T rotr(T x, unsigned int s) noexcept;
```

Returns: `s % N == 0 ? x : (x >> (s % N)) | (x << (N - (s % N)))`;

Remarks: Participates in overload resolution only if T is an unsigned integer type (3.9.1 [basic.fundamental]).

23.20.3 Counting [bitops.count]

```
template<class T>
constexpr int countl_zero(T x) noexcept;
```

Returns: The number of consecutive 0 bits, starting from the most significant bit. [Note: Returns N if `x == 0`.]

Remarks: Participates in overload resolution only if T is an unsigned integer type (3.9.1 [basic.fundamental]).

```
template<class T>
constexpr int countl_one(T x) noexcept;
```

Returns: The number of consecutive 1 bits, starting from the most significant bit. [Note: Returns N if `x == std::numeric_limits<T>::max()`.]

Remarks: Participates in overload resolution only if T is an unsigned integer type (3.9.1 [basic.fundamental]).

```
template<class T>
constexpr int countr_zero(T x) noexcept;
```

Returns: The number of consecutive 0 bits, starting from the least significant bit. [Note: Returns N if `x == 0`.]

Remarks: Participates in overload resolution only if T is an unsigned integer type (3.9.1 [basic.fundamental]).

```
template<class T>
constexpr int countr_one(T x) noexcept;
```

Returns: The number of consecutive 1 bits, starting from the least significant bit. [Note: Returns N if `x == std::numeric_limits<T>::max()`.]

Remarks: Participates in overload resolution only if T is an unsigned integer type (3.9.1 [basic.fundamental]).

```
template<class T>
constexpr int popcount(T x) noexcept;
```

Returns: The number of bits set to one in the value of `x`.

Remarks: Participates in overload resolution only if T is an unsigned integer type (3.9.1 [basic.fundamental]).

References

- ISO/IEC JTC1 SC22 WG21 [N3864](#): "A constexpr bitwise operations library for C++" by Matthew Fioravante
- ISO/IEC JTC1 SC22 WG21 [P0214R2](#): "Data-Parallel Vector Types & Operations" by Matthias Kretz
- ISO/IEC JTC1 SC22 WG21 [P0237R0](#): "On the standardization of fundamental bit manipulation utilities" by Vincent Reverdy and Robert J. Brunner
- ISO/IEC JTC1 SC22 WG21 [P0237R4](#): "Wording for fundamental bit manipulation utilities" by Vincent Reverdy and Robert J. Brunner
- ISO/IEC JTC1 SC22 WG21 [P0476R1](#): "Bit-casting object representations" by JF Bastien
- [ARM Compiler User Guide](#) [large PDF]
- [Intel x86 Instruction Set Reference](#) [large PDF]
- PowerPC Architecture Book, Version 2.02: [Book I: PowerPC User Instruction Set Architecture](#) [large PDF inside ZIP]